WALTZING MATILDA

Steal the sheep. Beat the troopers.



2–5 players | 10+ | 20–30 min

"Once a jolly swagman camped by a billabong… Down came a jumbuck to drink at that billabong; up jumped the swagman and grabbed him with glee… Down came the troopers, one, two, and three. Whose is that jumbuck you've got in your tucker bag?" Every hand plays the song in order.

HOW IT WORKS

A must-follow trick-taking game with two twists. One hand per player; the highest total wins.

- **Jumbucks are trump, and never dealt.** They wait at the Billabong. Win a trick and you may **grab** one.
- **Troopers** can be played at any time. They never win, and the **third ends the hand**.
- A Jumbuck still in your hand when the hand ends is **caught**, and costs points.

COMPONENTS



Yellow billy | Green windmill | Red bush hat | Blue swan | Jumbuck (trump) | Trooper

- **55 cards.** 40 camp cards in four suits, numbered 1 to 10; **12 Jumbucks**, numbered 1 to 12; **3 Troopers**.
- 1 **Billabong** card and 1 **score pad**. You also need a pencil.

YOUR TUCKER BAG

Your hand is your tucker bag. Every Jumbuck in it was stolen. It is trump, so it wins tricks, but it is also **evidence**. Play it before the troopers come, or you will be caught with it.

SETUP

Before the first hand

1. Write each player's name on the **score pad**.
2. The player who last slept outdoors is the first **dealer**.

At the start of every hand

3. **Billabong.** Put the Billabong card in the middle. Shuffle the 12 Jumbucks and stack them face down on it. Turn the top one face up: a jumbuck has come down to drink.
4. **Deal.** Count out the camp cards shown in the table, shuffle the 3 Troopers into them, and deal everyone the same number of cards. The camp cards left over stay out, face down and unseen.
5. The player to the dealer's left **leads the first trick**. Leave room beside the Billabong for the **trooper line**.



The Billabong card



12 Jumbucks; the top one face up

Players	Cards each	Camp cards counted out	Left out	Hands
2	12	21	19	2
3	12	33	7	3
4	10	37	3	4
5	8	37	3	5

PLAYING A TRICK

The leader plays a card, then each player in turn clockwise plays one. All cards go face up. **Lead a camp card.** You may only lead a Jumbuck or a Trooper if that is all you hold.

1. Follow

If you have a card of the **led suit**, you must play one.

2. Troopers

Instead of following, you may play a **Trooper** at any time, even if you could follow suit. It never wins and is not part of the led suit. Put it on the **trooper line** beside the Billabong: one, two, three.

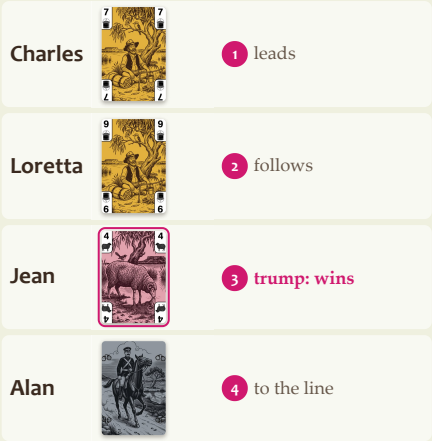
3. Trump

If you can't follow, play anything. A **Jumbuck is trump** and beats every camp card.

4. Win

The **highest Jumbuck** wins. If there is none, the **highest card of the led suit** wins.

EXAMPLE: WHO WINS THE TRICK



1. Charles leads the Yellow 7.
2. Loretta follows with the Yellow 9.
3. Jean has no Yellow, so she plays **Jumbuck 4**, a trump.
4. Alan could follow, but plays a **Trooper**. It goes on the line.

Jean wins: a Jumbuck beats any Yellow.

AFTER THE TRICK

Take the trick

The winner puts the trick's camp cards and Jumbucks **face down** in front of them as their pile. Troopers stay on the line.

The theft

The winner **may grab the drinking jumbuck**: put it in your hand, then turn up the next Jumbuck. Grabbing is optional, and **public**: everyone sees who took which sheep. If the Billabong is empty, there is nothing to grab.

The next trick

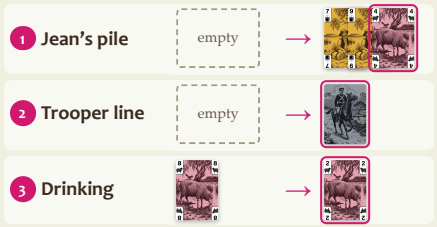
The winner leads.

A GRABBED SHEEP IS TRUMP, AND EVIDENCE

It is an ordinary card in your hand from now on: you can't lead it, and it counts against you if the hand ends first. A sheep grabbed on the **last** trick is caught at once.

EXAMPLE: AFTER THE TRICK

Jean won the trick in the example on the other side.



1 Jean takes the three cards face down: **1 trick** and **1 Jumbuck** banked.

2 Alan's Trooper is the first on the line.

3 Jean **grabs Jumbuck 8** into her hand. Jumbuck 2 is turned up. She leads next.

END OF A HAND

The hand ends after the trick in which the **third Trooper** is played, or after any trick when **a player has no cards left**. Then comes the reckoning.

1. **Caught.** Show your hand. Each Jumbuck still in it is caught. Troopers and camp cards cost nothing.
2. **Price.** Each caught sheep costs **1 point for each Trooper on the line**, minimum 1.
3. **Score.** +1 for each trick you won, +1 for each Jumbuck in the tricks you won (whoever played it), minus what you were caught with.
4. **Pad.** Write your score on the pad.
5. **Next hand.** Gather all 55 cards. The deal passes left. Start again at Setup, step 3.

Troopers on the line	none	1	2	3
The line				
Cost per caught sheep	–1	–1	–2	–3

NOBODY ON THE LINE

If a player runs out of cards before any Trooper is played, each caught sheep still costs **1**. The squatter rides up anyway. When the third Trooper ends the hand, each costs **3**.

EXAMPLE: THE RECKONING

Alan played the third Trooper, so the hand ends. Alan's tucker bag still holds two grabbed sheep:



	Tricks +1	Sheep banked +1	Caught –3	Score
Charles	3	2	0	**5**
Loretta	2	1	1	**0**
Jean	2	0	0	**2**
Alan	1	0	2	**–5**

Loretta: 2 + 1 − 3 = 0. Alan: 1 + 0 − 6 = **–5**. A negative score is fine.

END OF THE GAME

After **every player has dealt once**, add up the scores. The **highest total wins**.

Ties: if totals are tied, the tied player with the **most points in the last hand** wins. Still tied? Rejoice in shared victory.

AT A GLANCE

- **Your turn:** follow the led suit if you can, or play a Trooper. Can't follow? Play anything; a Jumbuck is trump.
- **Winning a trick:** take it, grab the drinking jumbuck or leave it, then lead.
- **The reckoning:** each Jumbuck left in your hand costs 1 for each Trooper on the line (at least 1).

THE WORDS

Swagman: a worker who travels on foot, carrying his swag.

Matilda: the swag, or bedroll.

Billabong: a pool cut off from a river.

Jumbuck: a sheep.

Tucker bag: a bag for food. Here, your hand.

Squatter: a big landholder who grazed sheep.

Troopers: mounted police.

Words from Marie Cowan's 1903 version of the song.

Game design: Dean Morris · Wombat Game Factory
wombatgamefactory.com
Rule book v4 · 04/11/2026 · Prototype art

WALTZING MATILDA

Words: Marie Cowan, 1903, after A. B. "Banjo" Paterson, 1895. Public domain.

Once a jolly swagman camped by a billabong
Under the shade of a coolibah tree,
And he sang as he watched and waited till his "Billy" boiled,
"You'll come a-waltzing Matilda, with me."

> CHORUS
> *Waltzing Matilda, waltzing Matilda,*
> *You'll come a-waltzing Matilda, with me,*
> *And he sang as he watched and waited till his "Billy" boiled,*
> *"You'll come a-waltzing Matilda, with me."*

Down came a jumbuck to drink at that billabong,
Up jumped the swagman and grabbed him with glee,
And he sang as he shoved that jumbuck in his tucker bag,
"You'll come a-waltzing Matilda, with me."

> *(Chorus)*

Up rode the squatter, mounted on his thoroughbred.
Down came the troopers, one, two, and three.
"Whose is that jumbuck you've got in your tucker bag?
You'll come a-waltzing Matilda, with me."

> *(Chorus)*

Up jumped the swagman and sprang into the billabong.
"You'll never catch me alive!" said he
And his ghost may be heard as you pass by that billabong:
"You'll come a-waltzing Matilda, with me."

> *(Chorus)*

After verses 2 to 4 the chorus is the same, but its third line repeats the third line of that verse.